CELEBRATING CINEMA

AN INTRIGUING NEW CROP OF INDIAN FILMS DEBUTS AT THE 48TH **TORONTO INTERNATIONAL FILM FESTIVAL**







(clockwise from top) stills from *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*, *Lost Ladies*, and *Dear Jassi*

Running from September 7 to 17, the 48th edition of the Toronto International Film Festival features a wide-ranging array of seven Indian films—documentaries, features in three different languages, mainstream Hindi productions, and even an animated short—in the lineup. Helmed by both emerging directors and filmmakers making a comeback to filmmaking after a considerable gap, these productions signal the appetite for homegrown storytellers to continue experimenting with their craft. Five titles to look out for:

VASUDHAIVA KUTUMBAKAM (The World is Family): Five years after *Reason* (2018), Anand Patwardhan, India's most influential documentarian, returns to filmmaking with his most personal film. Structured as a portrait of his parents, Patwardhan traces how their lives were intertwined with the tumultuous years of India's Independence movement. Employing intimate interviews with his parents and relatives regarding their memories of figures such as Jawaharlal Nehru, B.R. Ambedkar, and Mahatma Gandhi that Patwardhan filmed across three decades, *Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam* continues his preoccupation with examining the origins of the divisive politics that have raised tensions between Hindus and Muslims in an increasingly intolerant country.

KILL: The The only Indian film to premiere in the Midnight Madness section, Nikhil Nagesh Bhatt's martial arts thriller sees a passenger bound train for New Delhi becoming a bloody battleground when a pair of commandos square off against a 40-strong army of invading bandits. Inspired by real-life train robberies, *KILL* juxtaposes the action with a doomed love story, its breathless pace complemented by set pieces of close-quarters combat aboard a moving train. After all, there's nothing quite like a lovesick commando. Starring newcomer Lakshya and Tanya Maniktala, *KILL* is co-produced by Karan Johar's Dharma Productions and Guneet Monga's Sikhya Entertainment.

DEAR JASSI: Tarsem Singh Dhandwar (*The Fall*, 2006) marks his return to directing after eight years with his first India-set feature that recounts a terrifying real-life tale of a young couple who are desperate to be together but remain separated by time, distance, class, and familial expectations. Set largely in Punjab and scripted in Punjabi and English, *Dear Jassi* underlines the filmmaker's rigour, especially his ability to effortlessly switch between intimacy and brutality.

Documentarian Anand Patwardhan makes a comeback with Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, while Tarsem Singh Dhandwar returns to directing after eight years with Dear Jassi

LOST LADIES: After premiering her debut feature *Dhobi Ghat* (2010) at TIFF, Kiran Rao returns to the festival with her sophomore Hindi feature that follows two brides who get accidentally swapped before their big day. Set in 2001 in rural India, the film sees Rao craft an impossibly hilarious feminist coming-of-age tale that satirises patriarchal matrimony.

THIS IS TMI: The only Indian animated short in the line-up this year, Subarna Dash and Vidushi Gupta's *This is TMI* sees the filmmakers intercut eclectic stop-motion animation with a spirited, taboo-busting discussion among a group of women that takes place off-camera. Both playful and powerful, the film is an adept display of the storytelling versatility of its filmmakers. ■

Poulomi Das